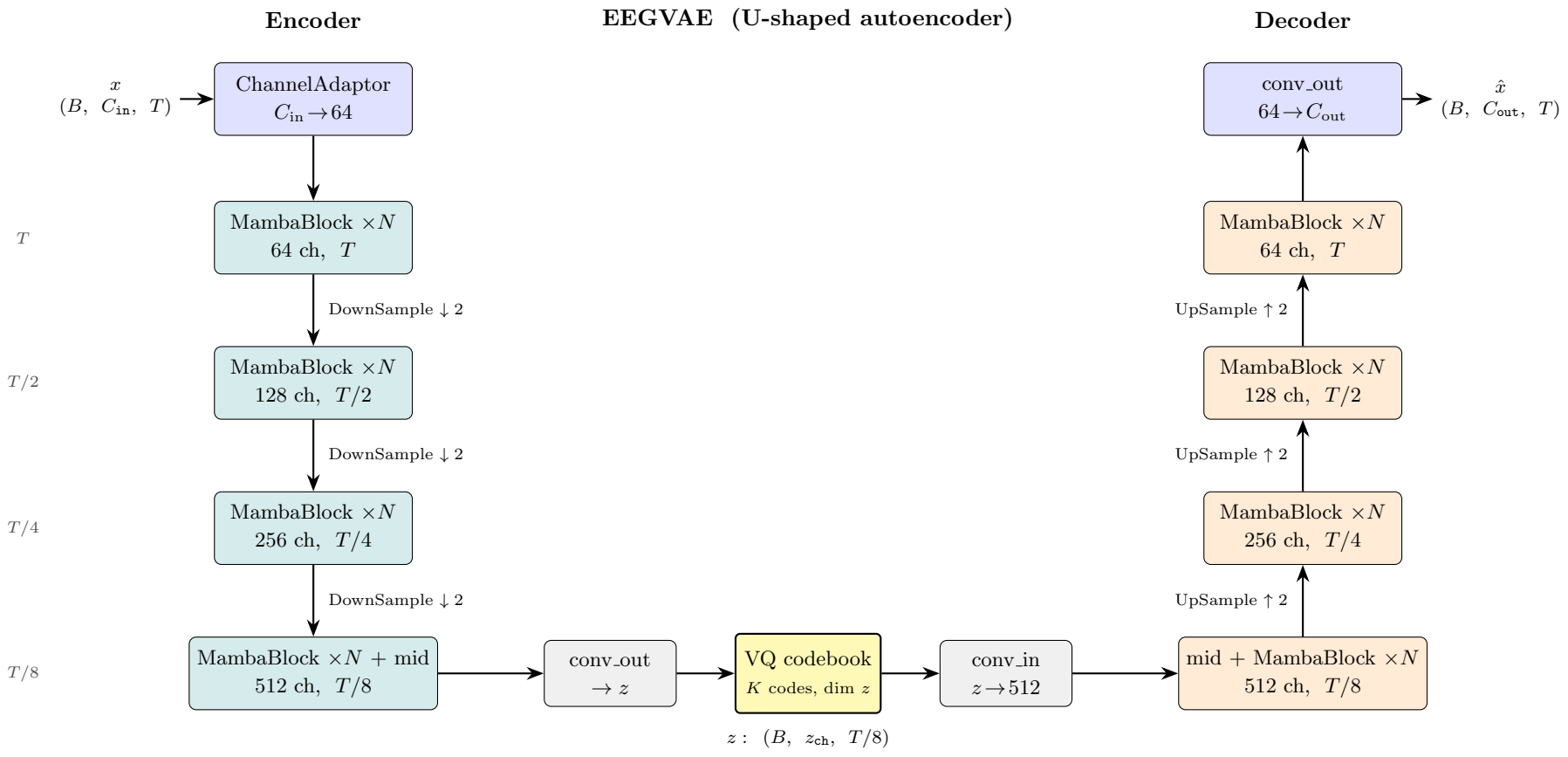


Bottleneck = quantize z to the nearest codebook entries (VQ) *or* a Gaussian posterior (KL).
Decoder mirrors the encoder — **no skip connections** (information passes only through z).